

Interaction of Animacy and Number: The Case of Odia, a Classifier Language

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1. Introduction

Languages are sensitive to the animacy factor of the nouns they refer to. They use varied grammatical devices like honorificity, case, plural markers, and classifiers, among many others, to differentiate animate referents from inanimate ones. For instance, Persian has two plural markers, *-ha* (1a), the general plural, and *-an* (1b), the animate plural marker.

(1) a. *mard/tan/ raxt-ha*
man/body/ garment-PL
'men/ bodies/ garments'

b. *mard/*tan/*raxt-an*
man/body/garment-PL^{++Animate}
Intended: 'men/ bodies/ garments'

(Persian: Bayanati & Toivonen, 2019, p. 159)

In a classifier language, the classifiers help categorize the nominals based on animacy (along with semantic attributes like shape, size, and functionality). In many classifier languages, the animate, especially the human nominals, are distinguished from their inanimate counterparts using distinct classifiers. For instance, in Bangla the classifier *jon* appears exclusively with [+Human] nouns, whereas *-te/ ta* is used elsewhere (2).

(2) a. *teen jon chhele*
three CL^{++Human} boy
'Three boys'

b. *teen te/*jon goru*
three CL/ CL^{++Human} cow
'Three cows' (Bangla)

This distinction is also evident in plural contexts without numerals. Bangla has two nominal plural markers *-ra* and *gulo*. The marker *-ra* (3a) is restricted to [+Human] nominals, while *gulo* (3b) appears with all kinds of nominals.

(3) a. *chhele/*goru/*tebil -ra*
boy/ cow/ table -PL^{++Human}
'boys/cows/tables'

b. *chhele/ goru/ tebil gulo*
boy/ cow/ table PL
'Intended: boys/cows/tables' (Bangla)

Thus, in classifier languages, animacy plays a crucial role in the categorization of nominals, particularly in determining their pairing with classifiers. In this context, animacy encompasses

not only the semantic distinction between animate and inanimate entities but also the grammatical features associated with them.

The current study examines the role of animacy in Odia, an Eastern Indo-Aryan (EIA) classifier language. It also highlights the interaction between animacy and number in the language. While much of the existing literature has discussed the relationship between grammatical animacy and other phi-features, such as, person (Alexiadou & Anagnostopoulou, 2006), number (Wiltschko & Ritter, 2015; Ozsoy, 2009), and gender (Hockett, 1966), there has been limited attention to how animacy behaves in the context of classifier languages. This study fills this gap by examining how animacy interacts with nominative-marked DPs and clauses in Odia.

In Odia, the distinction between animate and inanimate nominals is specifically evident in plural contexts. Animate nominals, such as *pila* ‘boy’ typically require specific markers like *maane*. It is distinct from the marker like *guDika*, which is used for inanimate items like *patra* ‘leaf’ (4).

- | | |
|--|---|
| (4) a. <i>pila-maane</i>
boy-PL
‘boys’ | b. <i>patra-guDika</i>
leaf-CL _{PL}
‘leaves’ |
|--|---|

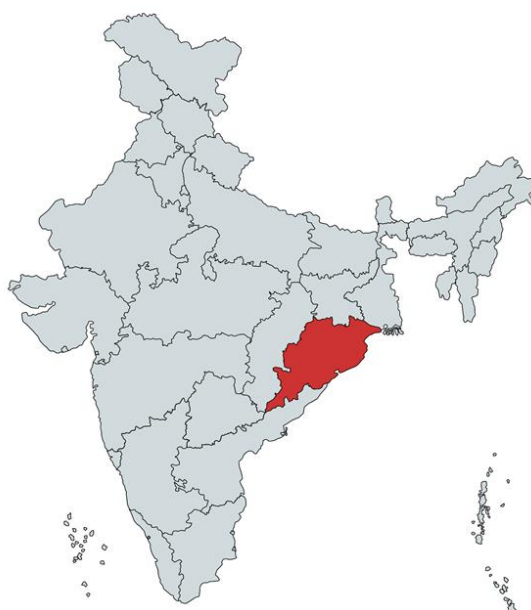
This formal treatment of animacy provides insights into how it interacts with number in the language. By focusing on how these features align in nominative-marked DPs, this study aims to contribute to a deeper understanding of the role of animacy in classifier systems, particularly in languages like Odia, where both animacy and number agreement¹ play central roles in structuring grammatical relationships.

The organization of the paper is as follows. In Section 2, we provide an overview of Odia and introduce the central issue related to the data. Section 3 explores the relationship between plural marking and animacy in detail, demonstrating that the interaction between the two is more complex than initially apparent. This discussion leads to an examination of the close connection between *maan* and *-e*. Sections 3.1 and 3.2 focus on the individual roles of *maan* and *-e*, respectively, establishing *-e* as an optional marker of animacy in Odia in Section 3.3. In Section 4, we argue that animacy is a formal feature in Odia, supported by Wiltschko’s (2009) diagnostics (subsection 4.1). This section also shows that animacy is projected syntactically as an Anim head above the DP (subsection 4.2). Section 5 concludes the study. Section 6 offers directions for future research.

2. Empirical Background and Core Arguments

Odia, primarily spoken in the state of Odisha in India (see Map 1), is an Eastern Magadhan language within the Eastern Indo-Aryan (EIA) family.

¹ Note that Odia also exhibits person agreement. In this paper we concentrate solely on number agreement.



(Map 1)

It is closely related to other EIA languages like Assamese and Bangla, sharing many syntactic and morphological features. Similar to its sister languages, Odia is a numeral classifier language exhibiting a nominative-accusative case alignment. Grammatically, Odia has a rich case system, including nominative, accusative, genitive, instrumental, dative, and ablative cases. Subjects are marked with the nominative case, while direct objects are marked with the accusative case. The language uses suffixes and postpositions rather than prepositions, which are placed after the noun to indicate grammatical relations (e.g., *re* for 'in', *ku* for 'to'). The typical word order in Odia is Subject-Object-Verb (SOV), similar to many other languages in the Indo-Aryan family. For illustrations, see example (5).

- (5) *rabi* *raama-ku* *maar-e*
Ravi.NOM Ram-ACC hit-PRS.3SG
'Ravi hits Ram.'
(Odia)

In this paper, we claim that animacy is a formal syntactic feature in Odia that plays a key role in both the nominal and clausal domain. The language has a dedicated animacy marker in the nominal domain, distinct from the plural marker and classifiers. The marker encodes animacy, distinguishing between animate and inanimate nouns in plurals. At the clausal level, the animacy is manifested in the form of number agreement. Notably, Odia exhibits a unique feature among EIA languages - number agreement on the clause, which, as we argue, is triggered by animacy (see examples 6-11). In Bangla (6-7) and Assamese (8-9), we do not notice any change in the verb when the DPs are singular (*se* in Bangla) and (*xe/tae* in Assamese) or plural (*ora* in Bangla) and (*xihote* in Assamese). However, in Odia (10-11), with singular DP *se* and plural DP *se-maane*, distinct number agreement markers are noted (*-e* and *-nti*, respectively).

- (6) *se* *skul-e* ***jaa-e***
he/she school-DAT go-PRS.3
'He goes to school.'

- (7) *o-ra skul-e jaa-e*
 they-PL school-DAT go-PRS.3
 ‘They go to school.’ (Bangla)
- (8) *xe/tae skul-loi jaa-e*
 he/she school-DAT go.PRS-3
 ‘He/She goes to school.’
- (9) *xihote skul-loi jaa-e*
 they.PL school-DAT go-PRS.3
 ‘They go to school.’ (Assamese)
- (10) *se skul-ku jaa-e*
 he/she school-DAT go-3SG
 ‘He goes to school.’
- (11) *se-maane skul-ku jaa-nti*
 they-PL school-DAT go-3PL
 ‘They go to school.’ (Odia)

This clausal agreement is a distinctive syntactic characteristic of Odia, reflecting the broader role of animacy in the language’s grammar. The following sections elaborate on this particular feature of Odia, with a focus on animacy.

3. Analyzing the problem: Interaction of plural and animacy

We begin with focusing on the characteristics of classifier DPs in Odia. In Odia, DPs follow the patterns seen in typical classifier languages (see Dutta, 2024 for a discussion on EIA classifier systems), with singular DPs posing no issues, as seen in (12).

- (12) Singular DPs
- | | | |
|--|---|---|
| a. <i>pila-Ti</i>
boy-CL
‘the boy’ | b. <i>bilei-Ti</i>
cat-CL
‘the cat’ | c. <i>patra-Ti</i>
leaf-CL
‘the leaf’ |
|--|---|---|

However, plural DPs are more complex constituting two types of DPs. The first type is a DP with numerals, where the classifier is selected based on the animacy of the DP (13). When the noun is [+Human], the classifier *jaNa* is used, while [-Human] nouns take the classifier *Ti* (13 b-c).

- (13) Plural DP (Type 1)
- | | | |
|---|--|---|
| a. <i>dui jaNa pila</i>
two CL _[+Human] boy
‘two boys’ | b. <i>dui-Ti bilei</i>
two-CL cat
‘two cats’ | c. <i>dui-Ti patra</i>
two-CL leaf
‘two leaves’ |
|---|--|---|

The second type of the plural DP introduces further nuance. In the absence of numerals, the plural marker *maane* is used for animate nouns (14a), whereas the plural classifier *guDika* is

used for inanimate nouns (14b) to mark plural. This allows for a clear distinction between animate and inanimate plurals. Interestingly, [+Animate], [-Human] nouns, such as ‘cat’, can either take *maane* or *guDika*, showing flexibility in plural marking (14c). This highlights that Odia is highly sensitive to animacy while forming plurals.

(14) Plural DP Type 2

- | | | |
|---|--|--|
| a. <i>pila-maane</i> /* <i>guDika</i>
boy-PL
‘boys’ | b. <i>patra-*maane/guDika</i>
leaf-PL/ CL _{PL}
‘leaves’ | c. <i>bilei-maane/guDika</i>
cat-PL/CL _{PL}
‘cat’ |
|---|--|--|

Now, we concentrate on the clause structure of Odia. The examples below show that verbal agreement is sensitive to the number information of the DPs. The morpheme *-e* is used on the verb in the presence of 3rd person singular subject (15), and *-nti* serves as the morphological verbal agreement marker in the case of 3rd person plural subject (16).

- (15) *se/ raam skul-ku jaa-e*
(S)he/Ram school-DAT go-PRS.3SG
‘(S)e/Ram goes to school.’ (3 SG, Present)

- (16) *se-maane/ pila-maane skul-ku jaa-nti*
they-PL/ boy-PL school-DAT go-PRS.3PL
‘They/ the boys go to school.’ (3 PL, Present)

However, it is seen that the plural agreement is restricted. It is only possible with [+Animate] DPs. The animate plural DP *pila-maane* ‘boys’ in (17) triggers number agreement on the verb. Such agreement is absent in (18) when the DP *tren-guDika* ‘trains’ is inanimate.

- (17) *pila-maane skul-ku jaa-uchha-nti*
boy-PL school-ACC go-PROG.PRS-3PL
‘The boys go to school.’

- (18) *tren-guDika jaa-uchh-i/ *jaa-uchha-nti*
train-CL_{PL} go-PROG.PRS-3.SG/go-PROG.PRS-3PL
‘Trains are moving.’

These examples (17-18) clearly show that the animacy distinction in Odia DPs extends beyond the noun's inherent properties and is reflected on the agreement marker. The morpheme *maane* can occur with animate DPs, which trigger number agreement (as seen in (17)), unlike inanimate DPs with *guDika* (as seen in (18)). The next subsection looks deeper into the structure of *maane* vis-à-vis discussion in the literature.

3.1 Analyzing *-maane*

Two separate accounts have been posited in the literature to study *maane*. Dash (2015) takes the entire unit *maane* as a plural without dividing it. She concurs with Sahoo (1996) and describes this *maane* as a number (plural) marker.

- (19) *pilaa-maane*
 child-PL
 ‘children’ (Dash, 2015)

The marker *maane* can appear neither before the noun (20), nor with a classifier (21).

- (20) **maane pilaa*
 PL child
 Intended: ‘children’

- (21) **pilaa jon maane*
 child CL^{+Human} PL
 Intended: ‘children’ (Dash, 2015)

Dash (ibid.) further claims that structurally *maane* is a plural, generated at NUM head inside DP. On the other hand, Tripathy (1963, p. 126) decomposes *maane* as *maan* and *-e*. In the absence of *maan*, the noun can either refer to an honorific singular or plural nominal (22). The use of *-maane* disambiguates the plurality interpretation (23).

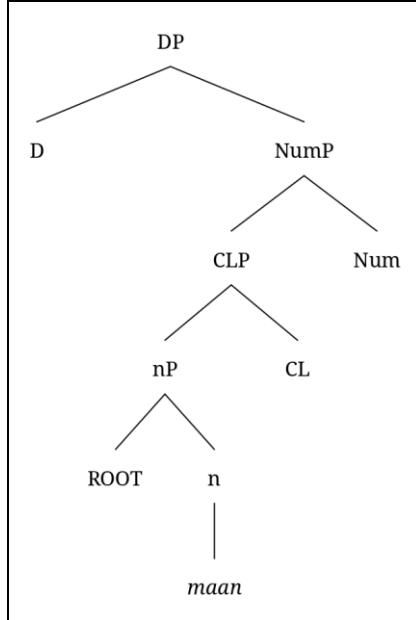
- (22) a. *siksak-e padh-nti* b. *siksak-e padh-nti*
 teacher-PL teach-PL.3PL teacher-SG teach-HON-3PL
 ‘Teachers teach.’ ‘The teacher (hon) teaches.’
- (23) *siksak-maan-e padh-nti*
 teacher-PL-E teach-3PL
 ‘Teachers teach.’

These examples exhibit that *-maan* and *-e* are two different morphemes. Further evidence of them being separate morphemes comes from examples (24-25). Example (24) is an instance of the existence of *maan* in non-nominative DP without *-e*. Example (25) shows the use of *-e* without *maan*.

- (24) *mu pila-maan-anku dekh-il-i*
 I boy-PL-ACC_{PL} see-PST-1SG
 ‘I saw the boys.’
- (25) *pila samast-e jaa-uchh-nti*
 boy all-E go-PROG.PRS-3PL
 ‘(All) boys are going.’

In relation to the position of *maan* in the DP structure, Banerjee (2024) describes *-maan* as a plural generated at the *n* head (26).

(26)



The following section is dedicated to know the status of *-e* and its relation with *maan*.

3.2 The status of *-e*

The suffix *-e* in Odia has been widely discussed in the literature, especially in terms of its pluralizing function. Tripathy (1963) defines *-e* as a marker that forms plurality, highlighting its restricted use with nominative case DPs. He emphasizes that *-e* is not used with “lower structure or inanimates,” focusing its function on pluralization for certain nominals in the nominative case. The following example illustrates its plural use.

- (27) *lok-maan-e skul-ku ja-nti*
 man-PL-E school-ACC go-PRS.3PL
 ‘People go to school.’

Tripathy argues that *-e* represents the original plural marker in Odia. Table 1 provides examples where *-e* is used to form the plural of nominals without *maan*.

Singular	Plural
<i>jhia</i> ‘girl’	<i>jhie</i> ‘girls’
<i>pua</i> ‘boy’	<i>pue</i> ‘boys’
<i>siksaka</i> ‘teacher’	<i>siksake</i> ‘teachers’
<i>mastara</i> ‘teacher’	<i>mastare</i> ‘teachers’

<i>pila</i> ‘child’	<i>pilae</i> or <i>pile</i> ‘children’
<i>bhuasuni</i> ‘daughter-in-law’	<i>bhuasunie</i> ‘daughters-in-law’
<i>bohu</i> ‘daughter-in-law’	<i>bohue</i> ‘daughters-in-law’

(Table 1)

The marker *-e* thus serves as a general plural marker, but Tripathy notes that it can cause ambiguity between pluralization and honorific meaning (as discussed earlier). The marker *-maan* is added to distinguish plural DPs from honorific singular. For example, in (22 repeated as 28), the sentence can either refer to ‘multiple teachers’ or ‘a teacher’ with an honorific, but in (23 repeated as 29), the plural interpretation is made clear by *-maane*.

- (28) *siksak-e padh-nti*
 teacher-E teach-3.PL
 ‘The teacher (honorific) teaches.’ / ‘Teachers teach.’

- (29) *siksak-maan-e padh-nti*
 teacher-PL-E teach-3.PL
 ‘Teachers teach.’

Tripathy (ibid.), takes instances like (29) as evidence to treat *maan* and *-e* as a compound plural suffix.² In contrast, Dash (2015) offers a different perspective. She treats *-maane* as a single plural marker, rejecting the distinction between *-e* and *-maan* as separate morphemes³. Dash’s analysis aligns with Sahoo (1996), who describes *maane* as a number (plural) marker rather than a marker that merely disambiguates honorific and plural readings.

In summary, this section surveys existing research on the plural function of *-e*, which is widely recognized in the literature. However, we argue that *-e*, despite its association with *maan*, should not be treated as a plural marker in all contexts. Further details of this argument are provided in the following section.

² Tripathy also notes an optionality in the plural marking: sometimes, the plural suffix is omitted if plurality is marked by the verb. However, this is rare. Examples such as (i-iii) demonstrate this phenomenon, where the plural interpretation is clear without the plural marker.

i. *chatra padh-nti* ii. *balika khel-nti* iii. *goru car-nti*
 student.PL study-PL girl.PL play-PL cow.PL graze-PL
 ‘Students study.’ ‘Girls play.’ ‘Cows graze.’

³ In contrast to the broader understanding of *-e* as a plural marker, Sahoo (1999) and Dash (2015) also identify *-e* as a multifunctional morpheme. *-e* can act as an indefinite marker in certain contexts, as seen in (i), or as a reduced numeral ‘one’ in constructions like (ii). These uses differ from the plural *-e* discussed in the study:

(i) *jan-e loka*
 CL-one man
 ‘A man’ (Dash, 1995)

(ii) *hajaar-e tanka*
 thousand-one rupee
 ‘One thousand rupees’ (Sahoo, 1999)

3.3 Importance of Animacy marker *-e* and Agreement

The marker *-e*⁴ occurs only with [+Animate], [+Plural] DPs. We claim that it is an optional animacy marker in Odia. For illustration, see examples below. In (30), *se/pila-maan-e* are [+Animate] DPs, in contrast to *kaar-guDika* in (31). As the examples show, *-e* (along with *maan*) comes only with animate plural DPs.

- (30) *se/pila-maan-e* *skul-ku* *jaa-nti*
 they/boy-PL-ANIM school-ACC go-PRS.3PL
 ‘They/ the boys go to school.’

- (31) *kaar-guDika* *jaa-e*
 car-CL_{PL} go-PRS.3SG
 ‘Cars go.’

Dasgupta (2018) claims that plural agreement in Odia is an honorificity agreement. We show evidence below that it is not true. Examples (32-33) show that the honorificity marker of Odia is different in the case of mid-honorific and high-honorific construction. The mid honorific (MHON) verbal marker *-a* is used in (32), where as the high honorific marker *-nti* is used in (33). This evidence shows that the marker *-nti* is not the only marker for honorificity.

- (32) *tume* *jaa-uchh-a*
 You.MHON go-PROG.PRS-2
 ‘You (HON) are going.’

- (33) *apaNa* *jaa-uchh-nti*
 you.HON.SG go-PROG.PRS-2.HON
 ‘You (HON) are going.’

We have shown that *-e* is an animacy marker present on Odia DP. But recall that animacy on TP is expressed via plural agreement. In other words, animacy triggers clausal agreement. Animacy can only trigger such syntactic operation if we assume it to be a formal feature. The following section gives evidence for animacy to be a formal feature, following (Wiltschko, 2009).

4. Animacy as a formal feature

Animacy has been studied as a formal feature cross-linguistically by Wiltschko (2009). It shows how languages differ in the nominal classification by comparing German, English, and Blackfoot. Blackfoot (a non-classifier language) does not possess mass/count distinction. Animacy fills this gap in Blackfoot to classify nominals. Animacy acts as a formal feature in

⁴ Banerjee (2024) proposed that animacy arises from an additional layer or a remnant head of the former Voice head, referred to as the "Voice-Remnant" head (Voice_{rem}). The external argument DP is generated in the base position of [Spec, vP]. After T assigns nominative case through agreement, the DP subsequently moves to [Spec, Voice_{rem}P]. This specific position in the structure imparts animacy features to the DP. However, it neither talks about how animacy works as a formal feature, nor shows the complexity that arises with the presence of the classifier. The current work discusses this issue in relation to the structural position of *-e*.

Blackfoot that behaves similarly to the ‘boundedness’ feature in German. In the following section, we present Wiltschko’s diagnostics to establish this claim.

4.1 Diagnostics for the formal status of animacy

We briefly discuss the four diagnostics presented by Wiltschko (2009) to test the formal status of animacy below.

I. Not a unique value for each nominal: Unlike gender, boundedness in German and animacy in Blackfoot are not uniquely determined for each nominal. The same noun can be animate or inanimate, with slight semantic differences. For example, while [-Animate] refers to the general substance that the noun refers to, the [+Animate] form refers to a more special form of the substance or a culturally newer item related to the original referent.

In Table 2, the item *ko's* refers to the referent ‘dish’ made of earthenware in [-Animate] contexts. However, in [+Animate] context, the same word refers to the culturally newer/more specific form of the dish made with tin or metal.

Morpheme	[-Anim]	[+Anim]	Meaning
<i>ko's</i>	✓		dish (earthenware)
<i>ko's</i>		✓	dish (tin/metal)
<i>ksisáiki'taan</i>	✓		arrowhead
<i>ksisáiki'taan</i>		✓	cartridge

(Table 2: based on Wiltschko, 2009, p.10)

II. Selectability: Animacy marking in Blackfoot is subject to selectability. The number marking in the language is sensitive to animacy. The singular and plural marking changes according to the animacy feature of the nominal (see Table 3).

	[Singular]	[Plural]
[+Anim]	<i>ponoká-wa</i> ‘elk-SG’	<i>ponoká-iksi</i> ‘elk-PL’
[-Anim]	<i>í'ksisako-yi</i> ‘meat SG’	<i>í'ksisako-istsi</i> ‘meat-PL’

(Table 3: based on Wiltschko, 2009, p.10)

Note that both the markers for singular and plural vary based on the animacy of the nominals. While *ponoká* ‘elk’, an animate noun, is marked with *-wa* for singular, *í'ksisako* ‘meat’, an inanimate noun, is marked with *-yi* for singular form. Similarly, for plural, *ponoká* ‘elk’ is marked with *-iksi* and *í'ksisako* ‘meat’ is marked with *-istsi*.

III. Mismatch: The other evidence for animacy being a formal feature in Blackfoot comes from the mismatches between the root and the nominal classification associated with it. In other

words, the animacy of a nominal is not predictable from its ontological properties in Blackfoot.

	Formal Animacy	Ontological Animacy
a. <i>pokón</i> ‘ball’	[+Anim]	[-Anim]
b. <i>isttoán</i> ‘knife’	[+Anim]	[-Anim]

(Table 4: Wiltschko, 2009, p. 11)

Further, the same nominal form can have either of the animacy values based on the context.

	[-Anim]	[+Anim]
[Singular]	<i>miistsis</i> ‘stick/branch’	<i>miistsis</i> ‘tree’
[Plural]	<i>miistsí-ístsi</i> ‘branches’	<i>miistsí-íksi</i> ‘trees’

(Table 5: Wiltschko, 2009, p. 8)

The noun *miistsis* in Table 5 can be used in the context where it is considered to be an animate being ‘tree’ or as an inanimate object ‘stick/branch’. Depending on the animacy value, the plural form also changes (-*ístsi* and -*íksi* for inanimate and animate contexts, respectively).

IV. Interaction with the verbal aspect: Similar to boundedness in German, animacy in Blackfoot interacts with the verbal classification. The verb stems are sensitive to the animacy of the nominal subject of the intransitive verbs and the object of the transitive verbs.

Taking cues from this study, we present three diagnostics to establish animacy as a formal feature in Odia.

I. No unique value for each nominal: Animacy value is not uniquely determined for the nominals. The same nominal can be considered as animate or inanimate depending on the context.

- (34) a. *jharaNa-maan-e* *naach-uchha-nti* **[+Animate]**
 waterfall-PL-ANIM dance-PROG.PRS-3PL
 ‘Waterfalls are dancing.’
- b. *jharaNa-guDika sukhi ga-l-a* **[-Animate]**
 waterfall-CL_{PL} dry go-PST-3SG
 ‘The waterfalls dried.’

In the example (34), the noun *jharaNa* ‘waterfall’ is not uniquely animate. The animacy value of the noun is obtained based on the contextual information. This is evident from the choice of plural used with the nominal. It can appear either with an animate plural (*maan-e*) or an inanimate plural (*guDika*), depending on the context. In (34a), the nominal ‘waterfall’ is personified as capable of ‘dancing’. Therefore, it appears with the animate plural *maan* and the

animate marker *-e*. In contrast, when the same nominal is devoid of contextual animacy, as in (34b), it is pluralized using the inanimate plural classifier *guDika*.

II. Selectability: The plural agreement on the clausal level is sensitive to the animacy feature of the nominal. The animate nominals trigger plural agreement.

- (35) a. *pila-maan-e* *jaa-uchha-nti* [+Animate]
 boy-PL-ANIM go-PROG.PRS-3PL
 ‘The boys have run away.’
 b. *tren-guDika* *jaa-uchh-i* [-Animate]
 train-CL_{PL} go-PROG.PRS-3SG
 ‘Trains are moving.’

The plural agreement on the verb (*-nti*) exists in the presence of the animate plural noun (35a) but not when the subject noun is inanimate (35b). In other words, the animacy feature triggers plural agreement. Further, the plural marker on the nominal also differs based on the animacy value of the noun (*maan* in 35a vs. *guDika* in 35b).

III. Mismatch: The ontological properties do not always match the formal animacy value of the nominal. In certain contexts, the ontologically inanimate nouns (star, statue, etc.) can be attributed to animacy interpretation when personified.

- (36) a. *tara-maan-e* *hasu-chha-nti*
 star-PL-ANIM smile-PROG.PRS-3PL
 ‘The stars are smiling.’
 b. *tara-guDika* *disu-chh-i*
 star-CL_{PL} see.INCH-PROG.PRS-3SG
 ‘Stars are seen.’
- (37) a. *murti-maan-e* *table* *upare* *thia* *he-l-e*
 statue-PL-ANIM table on stand be-PST-3PL
 ‘The statues stood on the table.’
 b. *murti-guDika* *paRi* *galaa*
 statue-CL_{PL} fall go.PST.3SG
 ‘The statues fell.’

The existence of the animacy marker *-e*, along with the animate plural *maan* on the noun *tara* ‘star’ in (36a), indicates that the inanimate noun bears [+Animate] value in this context. Consequently, the clausal plural agreement is visible on the verb. The noun *murti* ‘statue’ in (37a) follows the same pattern. However, plural agreement and the animate plural marker *maan* are absent in (36b and 37b) as the animacy values of the nouns are [-Animate].

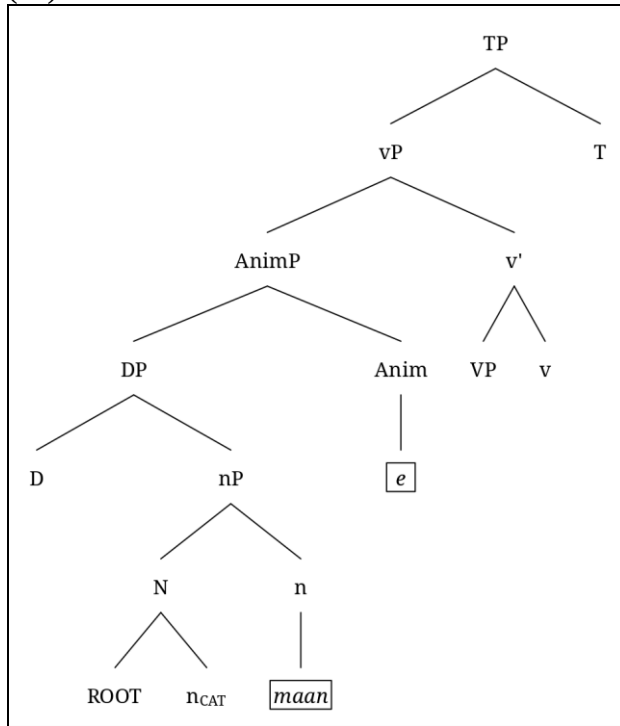
Thus, it is concluded that animacy in Odia is a formal feature capable of triggering syntactic operations like agreement. Since animacy is a formal feature, it must be a part of a functional head. In the subsequent section, we discuss the syntactic position of this feature in the derivation.

4.2 Position of Anim(acy) Head in the Structure

This section elaborates on the exact position of *-e* in the structure. In (38), structurally represented as (39), *-e* is the externalization of Anim head. AnimP heads DP in Odia. The structure in (39) also reveals how AnimP, instead of DP, triggers number agreement with the clausal T in Odia. The internal structure of AnimP also shows the positions of *maan* and *-e* on heads *n* and Anim, respectively.

- (38) *pila-maan-e* *skul-ku* *jaa-nti*
 boy-PL-ANIM school-ACC go-PRS.3PL
 ‘The boys go to school.’

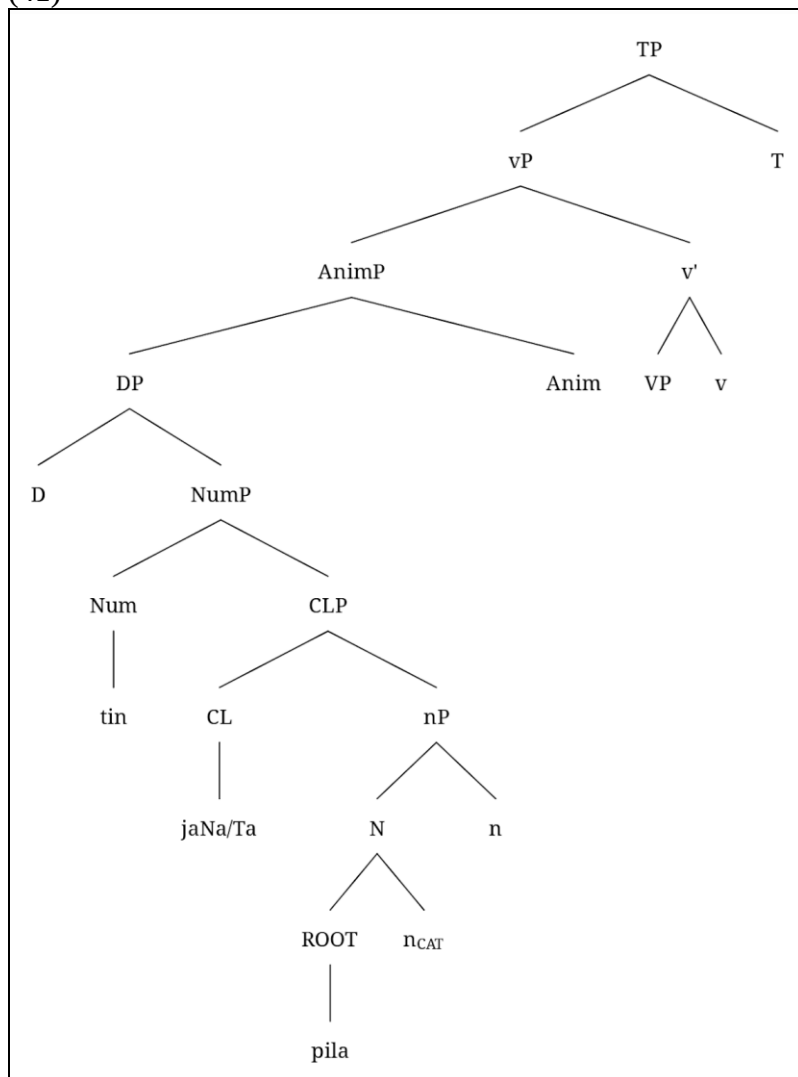
(39)



However, DP with classifier *jaNa* can also trigger agreement, as seen in (40) below.

- (40) *tin jaNa pila khel-uchh-nti*
 Three CL^{+uman} boy play-PROG.PRS-3PL
 ‘Three boys are playing.’

(41)



Very similar to (39), the representation (41) also shows the internal structure of AnimP. In (41), there is no plural marker (such as *maan*), rather, there is an animate classifier *jaNa*. However, the agreement mechanism remains the same where the AnimP triggers number agreement with T in the clause. In short, the *-e* marker in structure in (39) shows the presence of animacy on the Anim head on the DP. The structure in (41) highlights the presence of animacy through number agreement triggered by the morphologically null Anim head.

5. Conclusion

In the context of Eastern Indo-Aryan languages, which are typically classifier languages that encode semantic animacy within the DP, Odia stands out for its unique emergence of animacy as a formal feature. Animacy triggers agreement across the entire clause, particularly in terms of plural marking. Odia provides clear evidence of animacy functioning as a formal syntactic feature. This feature is manifested through a functional head, ‘Anim’. The ‘Anim’ head triggers plural agreement on the clause, thereby showing how animacy can have a direct impact on syntactic operations. In addition to triggering plural agreement, this functional head can also

exhibit an optional morpho-syntactic marker, *-e*, which combines with morphemes like *maan* and *samasta* (all) to further trigger agreement. Additionally, Odia makes use of a human classifier *jaNa*, which also plays a role in triggering agreement, particularly when referring to human beings. This classifier not only marks human referents but also works to establish agreement within the sentence. Thus, we see that Odia encodes animacy via varied means - functional heads, optional morphological markers, and specific classifiers.

This study establishes the significance of formal animacy in classifier languages. The ‘Anim’ head in Odia directs the choice of classifiers as well as clausal agreement. This observation opens the possibility of investigating other EIA classifier languages to determine whether a morphologically covert formal Anim head similarly accounts for the differentiation between animate and inanimate markers in those languages.

6. Way Forward

In some discourse contexts, the ontologically inanimate nouns appearing with the inanimate plural classifier *guDika* trigger plural agreement on the verb.

For example, in (42), the noun *kapada* ‘cloth’ is inherently inanimate and therefore appears with the inanimate plural classifier *guDika*. However, the verb agrees with the plural number of the nominal, as evident from the marker *-nti* on the verb. We find the same pattern with the nominal *murti* ‘statue’ in (43). In spite of being an ontologically inanimate noun occurring with the inanimate plural classifier, it triggers plural agreement on the verb.

- (42) *kapada-guDika* *ud-uchh-nti*
 cloth-CL_{PL} fly-PROG.PRS-3PL
 ‘The clothes are flying.’

- (43) *murti-guDika* *table* *upare* *thia* *he-l-e*
 statue-CL_{PL} table on stand be-PST-3PL
 ‘The statues stood on the table (on their own).’

This raises a challenge for the current analysis, which struggles to account for such constructions. Specifically, it remains unclear how animacy and number can be licensed in the absence of both an animate noun and an animate marker. A plausible hypothesis is that the animacy properties in Odia are not strictly ontological; rather, they are pragmatically driven by the discourse context. In these cases, the animacy is not inherently encoded in the noun or its morphology but emerges through the specific discourse circumstances, thereby triggering agreement in a way that is context-dependent. This suggests that animacy in Odia may be more fluid and discourse-sensitive, with the agreement mechanism being activated by contextual cues rather than fixed ontological features.

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